WRITING / DISCERNMENT / INNER AUTHORITY

The Art of Discernment

A workbook for developing intuitive awareness, psychological clarity, and inner authority



Kali Meister

A WORKBOOK · A PERSONAL ESSAY · A 15-DAY JOURNAL

KALIMEISTER.COM

A PLACE TO BEGIN

Inside these pages

01 The practice 3

Teaching, questions, and guided exercises

02 The personal journey 30

Kali’s essay on learning to trust what she knows

03 The daily journal 35

Fifteen days of guided writing



Section One

THE ART OF DISCERNMENT

A Workbook for Developing Intuitive Awareness, Psychological Clarity, and Inner Authority

Learning to distinguish what you know, what you feel, what you fear, and what you believe.

INTRODUCTION

What Is Discernment?

Discernment is the ability to recognize, examine, and evaluate information, experiences, emotions, and perceptions before deciding what they mean or how to respond.

It is the difference between having an experience and understanding that experience.

We often assume that because something feels true, it must be true. We mistake emotional intensity for accuracy, familiarity for safety, fear for intuition, and personal belief for objective reality.

We may even mistake our desire for something to be true as evidence that it is true.

Discernment asks us to slow down.

It asks us to consider the possibility that our first interpretation may not be our most accurate one.

For people who identify as intuitive, empathic, spiritually sensitive, or highly perceptive, discernment is especially important. Being receptive to experiences does not automatically mean we understand their origins or meanings.

Spiritual awareness and psychological awareness should complement one another, not compete.

This workbook is designed to help you develop the ability to:

- Recognize the difference between intuition and fear.
- Identify emotional reactions and psychological triggers.
- Understand projection and personal bias.

- Recognize spiritual bypassing.
- Establish healthy emotional and energetic boundaries.
- Examine intuitive and spiritual experiences critically.
- Develop confidence in your own decision-making.
- Become comfortable with uncertainty.

A foundational principle

Being intuitive does not mean being infallible.

Being compassionate does not mean being endlessly available.

Being spiritually aware does not mean being exempt from psychological accountability.

The goal is not to become less intuitive. It is to become more discerning.

REFLECTION NOTES

PART ONE

Knowing vs. Believing

Understanding the difference between perception, interpretation, and truth

One of the greatest obstacles to discernment is our tendency to confuse what we believe with what we actually know.

Human beings are meaning-making creatures. We constantly interpret our surroundings, assign meaning to experiences, and develop explanations for things we don't understand.

This is a natural psychological process.

However, the explanation we create is not necessarily the truth.

Consider this situation:

Someone you care about hasn't returned your phone call.

You might think:

- They are angry with me.
- I must have done something wrong.
- They are avoiding me.
- Something has happened to them.

These are interpretations, not established facts.

The fact is simply that they have not returned your call.

Everything beyond that is a conclusion you have drawn.

This distinction is fundamental to discernment.

Five levels of awareness

1. Observation

What actually happened?

What did you see, hear, or experience?

2. Emotion

What did the experience make you feel?

Were you anxious, disappointed, angry, frightened, excited, or relieved?

3. Interpretation

What meaning did you assign to the experience?

What explanation did your mind create?

4. Belief

What do you believe about the situation?

Is that belief supported by evidence, personal history, or assumption?

5. Discernment

After examining the experience, what can you reasonably conclude?

What remains unknown?

Exercise: Separate the facts from the story

Think of a recent situation that created an emotional reaction.

Complete the following:

1. What happened? Describe only observable facts.
2. What did I feel?
3. What did I immediately assume?
4. What evidence supports my assumption?
5. What evidence might contradict it?
6. What other explanations are possible?
7. What do I actually know?

Reflection

- How often do I treat my assumptions as facts?

- Do I tend to create explanations when information is missing?
- Am I comfortable admitting that I don't know?
- Have I ever discovered that something I believed with certainty was incorrect?

The practice

When you feel certain about something, ask:

Am I certain because I have evidence, or because the explanation feels familiar?

REFLECTION NOTES

PART TWO

Intuition vs. Anxiety

Learning to recognize the difference between inner awareness and fear-based responses

Intuition and anxiety can sometimes feel remarkably similar.

Both can create physical sensations, emotional responses, and an urge to take action.

You might experience a tightening in your stomach, a sense of urgency, an uncomfortable feeling around another person, or a sudden desire to withdraw.

The challenge is determining what those experiences mean.

Anxiety often involves anticipating a negative outcome. It may be connected to uncertainty, past experiences, perceived threats, or an attempt to maintain control.

Intuition is commonly experienced as an impression, awareness, or recognition that something deserves attention.

However, neither emotional calmness nor intensity proves that an impression is accurate.

A calm feeling can accompany an inaccurate belief. Anxiety can sometimes alert us to a legitimate concern.

The work is learning to investigate rather than automatically obey either experience.

How anxiety operates

Anxiety frequently asks us to anticipate, predict, prepare, and protect.

It may produce thoughts such as:

- Something terrible is going to happen.
- I need to figure this out immediately.
- I cannot relax until I know.
- I need to make sure everyone is okay.
- What if I am missing something?

- What if I make the wrong decision?

Anxiety often seeks reassurance, certainty, and control.

It can keep us mentally engaged with a situation long after there is anything productive left to consider.

How intuition may operate

Intuitive awareness may present itself as:

- Something about this situation deserves attention.
- I need more information.
- I am not comfortable proceeding.
- I need to establish a boundary.
- I should give this more time.
- This opportunity feels aligned with my values.

Intuition may be subtle or strong. It may arrive as an impression, an image, a thought, a physical sensation, or an immediate recognition.

The important distinction is that an impression is information to examine, not an unquestionable instruction.

Exercise: The source of the feeling

Think about a situation in which you experienced a strong internal reaction.

Answer:

1. What was the original feeling?
2. What thoughts followed it?
3. Did I begin imagining possible negative outcomes?
4. Did I feel pressured to act immediately?
5. Was I responding to something happening in the present or something I feared might happen?
6. Could a previous experience be influencing my reaction?

7. What information would help me evaluate this situation?

Reflection

When have I mistaken anxiety for intuition?

When have I ignored a legitimate concern because I didn't want to appear fearful?

What does uncertainty feel like in my body?

REFLECTION NOTES

PART THREE

The Language of Fear vs. The Language of Intuition

Fear speaks in questions. Intuition speaks in statements.

One of the most useful ways to begin developing discernment is to pay attention to the language of our internal dialogue.

Fear frequently speaks through questions.

- What if something terrible happens?
- What if they are lying to me?
- What if I make the wrong decision?
- What if I am not good enough?
- What if I missed something?
- What if I can't trust myself?
- What if they leave?
- What if I fail?

Fear creates possibilities and then asks us to live inside them.

It presents hypothetical outcomes as though they are impending realities.

The mind begins searching for answers to questions that may not have answers.

We can spend enormous amounts of emotional energy attempting to solve problems that have not happened.

Intuition, by contrast, may communicate through statements.

- Something isn't right here.
- I need to pay attention.
- This relationship has run its course.
- I don't feel comfortable moving forward.

- I need to wait.
- This is not mine to carry.
- I need to ask more questions.
- I am ready to make a change.

These statements describe an impression, a boundary, a recognition, or an awareness.

They do not necessarily predict the future.

Fear asks us to anticipate. Intuition invites us to recognize.

An important distinction

This is a useful framework, not an absolute rule.

Intuition can arrive as a question, and fear can make declarative statements.

For example, "I know something terrible is going to happen" is a statement, but it may be anxiety expressing itself with certainty.

The goal is to examine the emotional source and the evidence behind the thought rather than judging it by grammar alone.

Exercise: Who is speaking?

Read each statement.

Identify whether it sounds primarily like fear, intuitive awareness, or something that needs further investigation.

1. What if he leaves me?
2. I don't feel safe sharing this information with him.
3. What if I fail?
4. I am not ready to say yes.
5. What if everyone is judging me?
6. Something about this situation deserves closer attention.
7. What if I never find happiness?
8. I no longer want to participate in this relationship.

9. What if I am wrong?
10. I need to slow down before making this decision.

For each answer, explain why you categorized it that way.

Exercise: Transform the question

Take the following fear-based questions and turn them into grounded statements.

What if I can't handle this?

I can address challenges as they arise.

What if they don't like me?

I cannot control everyone's opinions.

What if I make the wrong choice?

I can make the best decision available with the information I currently have.

What if something bad happens?

I don't have evidence that something bad will happen. I can respond if circumstances change.

Now write five of your own.

1. What if _____?
2. What if _____?
3. What if _____?
4. What if _____?
5. What if _____?

Rewrite each one as a grounded statement.

Reflection

- Does my internal dialogue tend to begin with "what if"?
- Do I repeatedly ask myself questions that have no available answers?
- Am I confusing uncertainty with danger?

- Can I experience an intuitive impression without immediately creating a story around it?
- What might change if I stopped asking fear-based questions and started identifying what I actually know?

The central teaching

Fear wants certainty about the future.

Intuition offers awareness in the present.

Discernment is learning not to confuse the two.

REFLECTION NOTES

PART FOUR

The Psychology of Projection

Recognizing when we are seeing ourselves in other people

Projection occurs when we attribute our own feelings, thoughts, motives, or characteristics to someone else.

It is a psychological defense mechanism that can operate outside our conscious awareness.

We may assume someone is angry because we are angry.

We may believe someone is judging us because we are judging ourselves.

We may interpret another person's silence as rejection because rejection is something we fear.

Projection can also occur in spiritual relationships.

An individual may believe someone is carrying negative energy when they are actually experiencing their own discomfort, resentment, insecurity, or unresolved emotional response.

This doesn't mean every perception is projection.

It means we must be willing to examine the possibility.

Examples of projection

Example 1: Rejection

Someone doesn't invite you to an event.

You conclude they dislike you.

But perhaps they assumed you were unavailable.

Example 2: Dishonesty

You feel uncomfortable around someone and immediately conclude they are dishonest.

Your discomfort may be meaningful, but you don't yet know the reason.

Example 3: Judgment

You believe someone is judging your decisions.

You may actually be struggling with your own uncertainty about those decisions.

Exercise: Looking in the mirror

Think about someone who consistently provokes a strong emotional response in you.

Answer:

1. What specifically bothers me about this person?
2. What characteristics do I believe they possess?
3. Do I recognize any of these characteristics in myself?
4. Am I reacting to their behavior or my interpretation of their behavior?
5. Does this situation remind me of someone from my past?
6. What would I think if I didn't have an emotional history with this person?

Deeper reflection

What qualities do I have difficulty accepting in myself?

What qualities do I judge most harshly in others?

Are there things I accuse others of doing that I sometimes do myself?

Practice

Before making a judgment about another person's motives, ask:

What else could explain this behavior?

You don't have to excuse someone's behavior to examine your interpretation of it.

PART FIVE

Spiritual Bypassing and Unhealed Wounds

When spirituality becomes a way to avoid psychological work

Spirituality can provide meaning, comfort, hope, and a framework for understanding life's experiences.

It can also become a way to avoid uncomfortable realities.

Spiritual bypassing occurs when spiritual beliefs or practices are used to avoid unresolved emotional issues, psychological pain, difficult relationships, or personal responsibility.

It can happen intentionally or unconsciously.

Consider these statements:

- Everything happens for a reason.
- I am choosing love and light, so I don't need to be angry.
- They are just operating at a lower vibration.
- I have forgiven them, so I shouldn't still be hurting.
- I don't need therapy. I can heal this energetically.
- That person is part of my soul contract, so I have to keep them in my life.
- I am above negative emotions.

These beliefs may contain meaningful spiritual ideas, but they can also be used to dismiss legitimate emotional experiences.

Anger is not inherently unspiritual.

Grief is not a failure of faith.

Setting boundaries is not a lack of compassion.

Seeking psychological support does not diminish spiritual development.

The difference between acceptance and avoidance

Acceptance acknowledges reality.

Avoidance attempts to escape it.

Forgiveness does not require reconciliation.

Compassion does not require continued access.

Understanding someone's trauma does not eliminate their responsibility for their behavior.

And healing does not mean you will never experience difficult emotions again.

Exercise: Where am I bypassing?

Consider an area of your life where you are experiencing discomfort.

Answer:

1. Am I using spirituality to explain something I don't want to confront?
2. Am I telling myself I should be more evolved than my emotions?
3. Am I avoiding anger because I believe anger is negative?
4. Have I confused forgiveness with allowing someone continued access to me?
5. Am I accepting unacceptable behavior because I believe I am supposed to be compassionate?
6. What practical action might be necessary alongside my spiritual practices?

Reflection

What emotions do I have difficulty allowing myself to experience?

What have I labeled negative that might actually be necessary information?

Where have I used spiritual language to avoid a difficult conversation or decision?

Practice

Instead of saying:

"Everything happens for a reason."

Try:

"I may eventually find meaning in this experience, but I am allowed to acknowledge that it hurts."

Instead of:

"I need to raise my vibration."

Try:

"I need to understand what I am feeling and determine what would genuinely help me."

Instead of:

"I need to forgive and move on."

Try:

"I can work toward releasing the hold this experience has on me while maintaining the boundaries I need."

REFLECTION NOTES

PART SIX

Discernment in Relationships

Understanding boundaries, manipulation, compassion, and emotional responsibility

Relationships are one of the most challenging places to practice discernment because emotions complicate our ability to evaluate situations objectively.

We may see someone's potential rather than their behavior.

We may confuse being needed with being loved.

We may mistake familiarity for compatibility.

We may repeatedly explain away behavior because we understand someone's history.

For people who identify as empathic or highly sensitive, there may be an additional challenge: taking responsibility for emotions and circumstances that belong to other people.

Understanding someone does not mean you are responsible for them.

You can recognize someone's pain without becoming responsible for healing it.

Potential versus behavior

One of the most important relationship distinctions is the difference between who someone could be and how they consistently behave.

Someone may have enormous potential.

They may have experienced trauma.

They may genuinely love you.

They may have good intentions.

None of those things automatically makes a relationship healthy.

Discernment examines patterns rather than promises.

Recognizing manipulation

Manipulation can involve:

- Guilt as a means of controlling behavior.
- Repeatedly shifting responsibility.
- Denying or minimizing another person's experience.
- Using affection as a reward or punishment.
- Creating urgency to prevent thoughtful decisions.
- Making someone feel responsible for another person's emotional stability.
- Repeatedly violating boundaries.

One incident does not necessarily establish a pattern, but repeated behavior deserves attention.

Exercise: The relationship inventory

Think about an important relationship.

Answer:

1. Do I feel free to express disagreement?
2. Can I establish boundaries without excessive guilt?
3. Are my needs acknowledged?
4. Does this person take responsibility for their behavior?
5. Do their actions consistently match their words?
6. Am I staying because of what the relationship is or what I hope it will become?
7. Do I feel responsible for this person's happiness?
8. What would I advise someone I love if they described this same relationship?

Reflection

Do I confuse compassion with obligation?

Do I feel guilty when I prioritize my own needs?

Have I ever remained in a situation because I believed understanding someone's pain meant tolerating their behavior?

Practice: The responsibility line

Write down three things that are your responsibility and three things that belong to someone else.

Examples:

My responsibility:

- My decisions.
- My boundaries.
- My behavior.

Their responsibility:

- Their emotions.
- Their choices.
- Their accountability.

Remember:

You can care deeply about someone without carrying their life for them.

REFLECTION NOTES

PART SEVEN

Discernment in Spiritual Practice

Maintaining spiritual openness without abandoning critical thinking

Spiritual practice can involve intuition, tarot, astrology, mediumship, energy work, synchronicity, dreams, and other experiences that may carry personal significance.

These experiences can be meaningful.

However, meaning and factual certainty are not necessarily the same thing.

A tarot card can provide an opportunity for reflection without guaranteeing a particular outcome.

An astrological placement can offer a symbolic framework without determining someone's personality or future.

A dream can reveal something about your internal emotional world without being a prediction.

A perceived intuitive impression can be worth exploring without being treated as proof.

Discernment allows us to remain spiritually curious while acknowledging the limits of what we can know.

The danger of confirmation bias

Confirmation bias is our tendency to notice and favor information that supports what we already believe.

For example, you may believe someone is dishonest.

You notice every inconsistency in their behavior but overlook information that suggests otherwise.

The same thing can happen during spiritual readings.

If you expect a particular card to mean betrayal, you may interpret every surrounding card through that expectation.

Discernment requires considering alternative interpretations.

Tarot and discernment

When working with tarot, ask:

1. What does this card traditionally represent?
2. What does it bring up for me emotionally?
3. Am I interpreting the card through my expectations?
4. What alternative interpretations are possible?
5. Am I presenting a possibility as a certainty?
6. Does this interpretation encourage the person to exercise their own judgment?

A reading should not replace someone's ability to make informed decisions.

Mediumship and intuitive impressions

When receiving an impression, distinguish between:

- What you directly experienced.
- What you interpreted that experience to mean.
- What you subsequently communicated.
- What can actually be verified.

Avoid filling in missing information simply because you feel pressure to provide an answer.

Being honest about uncertainty is an expression of integrity, not a failure of intuitive ability.

Exercise: The intuitive investigation

Recall an intuitive impression you have experienced.

Document:

1. What was the original impression?
2. Did it arrive as a feeling, image, thought, physical sensation, or something else?
3. What did I initially believe it meant?
4. What other explanations were possible?
5. Was any part of the experience independently verified?
6. Did I change my interpretation after receiving additional information?

7. What did I learn about my own perception?

Reflection

Can I remain spiritually open without needing every experience to have a supernatural explanation?

Can I acknowledge that I might be wrong?

Do I feel pressure to provide certainty when working with others?

Practice

Replace the statement:

"This is definitely what is happening."

With:

"This is the impression I am receiving. Let's explore what it might mean."

REFLECTION NOTES

PART EIGHT

Developing Your Own Inner Authority

Learning to trust yourself without requiring certainty

Inner authority is the ability to make decisions based on your values, knowledge, experience, and considered judgment.

It is not the absence of doubt.

It is not the belief that you are always right.

It is the willingness to take responsibility for your decisions without constantly surrendering your judgment to other people.

Some people seek reassurance because they do not trust their own decisions.

Others seek repeated spiritual readings, opinions, signs, or external validation because uncertainty feels intolerable.

External guidance can be valuable.

But when we become dependent on it, we may gradually lose confidence in our own ability to evaluate situations.

Discernment helps us reclaim that ability.

The difference between guidance and dependency

Guidance provides additional perspective.

Dependency requires external permission.

Guidance encourages reflection.

Dependency discourages independent decision-making.

Guidance helps you consider possibilities.

Dependency makes you believe you cannot proceed without someone else's answer.

Exercise: Reclaiming your authority

Think about a decision you have been struggling to make.

Answer:

1. What decision am I facing?
2. What do I already know?
3. What information am I missing?
4. Whose opinion am I giving the most weight?
5. Am I seeking advice or permission?
6. What am I afraid will happen if I make this decision myself?
7. What choice best reflects my values?
8. Am I willing to accept responsibility for the outcome?

Reflection

When did I first begin doubting my own judgment?

Whose approval do I still seek?

What would my life look like if I trusted myself to make decisions without needing everyone to agree?

Practice: Making decisions without perfect certainty

Choose one small decision this week.

Gather the information you need.

Consider your options.

Evaluate the possible consequences.

Make the decision.

Resist the urge to repeatedly revisit it simply because uncertainty remains.

Afterward, reflect on what you learned.

CONCLUSION

Discernment Is a Practice, Not a Destination

Developing discernment is not about reaching a point where you never misinterpret an experience, misjudge a person, or make an incorrect decision.

That is impossible.

It is about developing the willingness to examine yourself honestly.

It is about recognizing that your emotions are valid experiences but are not always accurate descriptions of external reality.

It is about remaining open to spiritual experiences while acknowledging that interpretation requires care.

It is about understanding that intuition does not eliminate the need for evidence, and evidence does not require you to ignore your internal experiences.

Most importantly, discernment requires humility.

The ability to say:

"I may be wrong."

"I don't know."

"I need more information."

"I need to reconsider."

"I was reacting from fear."

"I was projecting."

"I confused what I wanted with what was happening."

These are not admissions of weakness.

They are expressions of psychological maturity.

Final reflection

Take some time to consider the following questions:

1. What have I learned about the way I process information?
2. What patterns have I recognized in my relationship with fear?
3. Where do I tend to confuse feelings with facts?
4. What beliefs am I now willing to question?
5. How has my understanding of intuition changed?
6. Where do I need stronger boundaries?
7. What does spiritual maturity mean to me now?
8. What does trusting myself actually look like?

A final thought

Being intuitive is not about having all the answers.

Being spiritually aware is not about being above human experiences.

Being discerning is about having the courage to examine what you believe, the humility to recognize what you don't know, and the wisdom to decide what deserves your trust.

You do not have to abandon your intuition to develop discernment. You have to become responsible for how you interpret it.

REFLECTION NOTES

Section Two

The Art of Discernment: How I Learned to Trust What I Know From My Personal Journey

I've been thinking a lot about discernment lately. Not the dictionary definition of the word, and not the kind of discernment that gets packaged up into a neat little spiritual lesson. I'm talking about the kind that takes years to develop. The kind you sometimes have to fight for. The kind that asks you to trust yourself while also being willing to question yourself.

For me, this has been a lifelong process.

I have known things for as long as I can remember. I was probably three or four years old when I began seeing, hearing, and experiencing things that I couldn't quite explain. At that age, I didn't have a name for any of it. It was simply part of my experience of the world. I didn't know that other people might not experience the world in the same way.

Of course, eventually I figured that out.

I grew up in a small town in Texas. My father's family was Catholic, and my mother's family was Baptist. Neither tradition, at least in my experience growing up, offered much room for the kinds of things I was experiencing. I was already a creative, somewhat different kid, and I didn't particularly want another reason to feel like I didn't fit in.

When I was about fifteen, I told my father that I could see and hear people who had died. His response was simple: "No, you don't."

And that was the end of that conversation.

It is interesting how much power a few words can have when you're young. I didn't stop having the experiences. I just became much more careful about talking about them. Sometimes people were curious. Sometimes they were frightened. Sometimes they questioned whether I was making things up or looking for attention. I learned to be selective about what I shared and with whom I shared it.

Every now and then, my abilities became something of a party trick. There was the familiar, "Here's Kali. She sees dead people. She can feel energy. She can hear your grandmother. She can find your car keys."

People might be entertained by it, but that didn't necessarily mean I felt safe being open about it. There is a difference between people being fascinated by something about you and people actually understanding you.

For a long time, I kept that part of myself tucked away.

I went back to college in my thirties as a nontraditional student. I had struggled academically when I was younger, and I had suspected since about third grade that I had dyslexia and attention-related learning difficulties. I wanted to understand how I learned, why certain things were difficult for me, and what I could do to become a better student. I went through an extensive psychological evaluation that involved somewhere between twenty-three and twenty-five hours of testing.

What I didn't anticipate was that the testing would bring me face-to-face with another question I had spent much of my life avoiding.

I told the clinician, who had a PhD, that I saw people who had died and that I heard things. I was nervous about it. There was mental illness in my family, and I didn't want to make assumptions about my own experiences without understanding them. I wanted to know what was happening. I wanted to be honest with myself.

The evaluation identified learning difficulties, including dyslexia and difficulty with numbers, as well as some depression. It did not identify the major psychiatric conditions I had worried about. I remember crying afterward. I was relieved, but I was also conflicted. I realized that I couldn't keep pretending this part of my life didn't exist. I needed to learn about it, understand it, and decide how I was going to live with it.

I want to be clear about something: I believe mental illness is real. I believe people deserve compassion, understanding, and appropriate professional care. I don't believe that every unusual experience is psychic, any more than I believe that every unusual experience is a sign of mental illness. I had to learn that I could take my own experiences seriously without dismissing the importance of psychological health.

That distinction matters to me.

In many ways, that evaluation gave me permission to stop hiding. I began to reclaim the word psychic. And I had a surprisingly difficult time doing that.

For people who grew up in the seventies, eighties, and nineties, the word psychic often came with a certain reputation. We were shown images of con artists, ridiculous television advertisements, exaggerated accents, and people supposedly trying to separate unsuspecting customers from their money. The word had baggage. I knew what I experienced, but I wasn't always comfortable with the label.

I tried other words. Empath. Intuitive. Sensitive. And people would inevitably respond, "Oh, so you're psychic."

Eventually, I decided I was going to own the word. I didn't have to accept every stereotype attached to it. I could define what it meant in my own life and in my work.

Today, I think there is room for a much more meaningful conversation between psychology, spirituality, intuition, empathy, and psychic experience. I don't think we have to make enemies out of things simply because we don't fully understand how they fit together. I would love to see those fields become more comfortable speaking to one another.

But reclaiming the word psychic didn't automatically mean I knew how to trust everything I experienced. That was another journey altogether.

One of the most important things I've learned is that having an experience and understanding what that experience means are two different things.

I can feel something. I can hear something. I can see something. I can have an unmistakable sense that I know something. But the moment I begin interpreting it, I have to be willing to examine what I'm bringing to the experience.

Am I responding to what I actually sense, or am I responding to what I fear might happen? Am I picking up on something, or am I hoping for a particular outcome? Am I listening, or am I trying so hard to get an answer that I'm supplying one myself?

This is where discernment becomes important.

One distinction I've found particularly interesting is the difference between the way fear speaks and the way intuition speaks. Fear often comes at us in questions.

What if something terrible happens? What if they leave? What if I fail? What if I'm wrong? What if I can't handle it?

Fear can create an entire future, complete with a cast of characters and a disastrous ending, before anything has actually happened.

Intuition, on the other hand, often seems to arrive as a statement.

Something isn't right here.

Pay attention.

This is not where you need to be.

You need to make a change.

That doesn't mean every question is fear or every statement is intuition. We have to be careful about turning observations into rigid rules. But I've found it useful to notice the difference. Fear tends to pull me into a cycle of possibilities. A genuine sense of knowing often feels more direct.

And even then, I still have to use discernment. A strong feeling is not automatically a fact. An impression is not automatically an instruction. I have to look at the information, the circumstances, and the consequences before deciding what to do with it.

I began exploring this more deliberately through my own spiritual study. One of the teachers who had a profound influence on me was Paul Selig. I was fortunate enough to attend Goddard College while he was directing the program. I didn't go there knowing the extent of his work in the metaphysical community, but watching his development and learning from him became an important part of my own journey.

One exercise I learned through that experience changed the way I thought about knowing.

The exercise is deceptively simple. You begin by getting quiet. You breathe, ground yourself, and allow your body to relax. Then you ask yourself questions to which you already know the answers.

What's my name? What color shirt am I wearing? What's my mother's name? What's the name of my first pet? What street do I live on? What's my spouse's name?

The point isn't to test whether you know the answers. Of course you know the answers. The point is to pay attention to how the answers arrive.

Where do you experience that knowing? Does it seem to come from your head, your chest, your throat, or somewhere else? Does it have a voice? Is it visual? Is it a feeling? Is it quiet or loud? Does it seem to have a particular quality or personality?

I became interested in the experience of the knowing itself, rather than simply the information it gave me.

Once you've begun to recognize how that knowing feels or sounds to you, you can move on to questions whose answers you don't yet know but will eventually be able to verify. When will that expected phone call arrive? When will the package show up? What day will the doctor's office schedule your appointment?

Then you give yourself time to see what happens.

And here's something I think is important: don't be disappointed if nothing happens immediately. I certainly wasn't someone who got it all figured out on the first try. In my case, it took repeated practice. Sometimes you may hear nothing at all. Sometimes you may feel tired or frustrated. If that happens, stop. Rest. Pay attention to your body. You don't have to force an experience to prove that something is happening.

I also learned that the experience of knowing doesn't necessarily arrive in the way we expect. We may imagine that guidance should sound soft, sweet, gentle, and comforting. But sometimes an experience can be surprisingly loud or unfamiliar. That doesn't mean we should automatically accept it, and it doesn't mean we should automatically be frightened by it either. We can ask for our experiences to come in a way that feels manageable and respectful of our own boundaries.

For me, that is part of discernment, too: learning that I have a say in how I engage with my spiritual life.

I can be open without being indiscriminate. I can be curious without being reckless. I can listen without automatically obeying. And I can question an experience without dismissing myself.

Over the years, I've also learned that the people around us matter. When we share something deeply personal and are met with ridicule, fear, or judgment, we can begin to doubt ourselves. Sometimes we spend so much energy trying to convince other people that our experiences are real that we lose touch with the more important question: What do these experiences mean to me, and how do I responsibly work with them?

I don't believe we need everyone to agree with us. I do believe we need room to explore, learn, and grow. And I believe we need people in our lives who can have a conversation with us without immediately deciding that they know everything about our experience.

I am still learning. I don't consider myself finished, and I certainly don't believe that being intuitive or psychic makes me infallible. I have been wrong. I have misunderstood things. I've allowed my own hopes and expectations to influence what I thought I was receiving. That's part of being human.

The goal isn't to become someone who never makes a mistake. The goal is to become someone who can recognize the difference between what they know, what they feel, what they fear, and what they are assuming.

That's what the art of discernment has come to mean to me.

It is the willingness to honor your experiences while remaining responsible for your interpretations. It is learning to recognize your own voice, your own patterns, and your own fears. It is knowing when to listen, when to question, when to wait, and when to let something go.

I spent a good portion of my life trying to make this part of myself smaller so that other people would be more comfortable. I don't do that anymore. But I also don't believe that trusting myself means I should stop examining what I believe.

Those two things can exist together.

I can trust what I know and still ask questions. I can embrace my spiritual experiences and still value psychology. I can listen to my intuition without handing over my judgment.

And perhaps that is where discernment really begins: not in having all the answers, but in learning how to recognize the difference between the answers we are given, the answers we want, and the answers we are afraid of.

I'm still listening. I'm still learning. And I'm still discovering just how much there is to know about knowing.

Section Three

THE ART OF DISCERNMENT

15-Day Guided Writing Journal

An invitation to examine what you know, what you feel, what you fear, and what you believe.

Instructions

Set aside 15–20 minutes each day for writing.

Find a quiet space where you can be honest with yourself. There are no right or wrong answers. You are not writing to impress anyone, defend your decisions, or arrive at a particular conclusion.

Write what is true for you in the moment.

Don't censor uncomfortable thoughts. Don't rush to resolve contradictions. Allow yourself to discover things you may not have previously considered.

The purpose is not perfection. It is awareness.

DAY 1: What Do I Actually Know?

Theme: Separating facts from assumptions

We often move through life believing we know things that we have actually interpreted, assumed, or accepted without examination.

Today, consider how often you confuse your understanding of a situation with the situation itself.

Writing prompts:

1. Think of something you currently believe about another person. What actual evidence supports that belief?
2. How often do you fill in missing information with your own assumptions?
3. Have you ever been absolutely certain about something only to discover you were wrong?
4. What makes it difficult for you to admit that you don't know something?

Deeper question:

What belief am I holding onto that I have never really questioned?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 2: The Questions Fear Asks

Theme: Recognizing fear-based thinking

Fear frequently speaks through questions. What if something goes wrong? What if I am rejected? What if I fail?

These questions can keep us trapped in imagined futures rather than allowing us to experience the present.

Writing prompts:

1. What are the three most common "what if" questions I ask myself?
2. What am I afraid might happen?
3. Has what I fear actually happened, or am I anticipating a possibility?
4. How much of my daily emotional energy is spent preparing for things that may never happen?
5. What would change if I stopped treating every possibility as a probability?

Deeper question:

How much of my life am I living in response to things that haven't happened?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 3: The Statements Intuition Makes

Theme: Recognizing internal awareness

Intuition may arrive as a simple recognition rather than an elaborate explanation.

Sometimes we know we need to pause, establish a boundary, reconsider a decision, or pay attention.

Today, explore your relationship with these impressions.

Writing prompts:

1. Describe a time when you experienced a strong intuitive impression.
2. What did that impression feel or sound like?
3. Did you immediately trust it, question it, or dismiss it?
4. Did you create a story around the impression before you had enough information?
5. Looking back, what did you learn from the experience?

Deeper question:

Can I acknowledge an impression without immediately deciding what it means?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 4: When My Past Speaks for My Present

Theme: Recognizing emotional triggers

Our previous experiences influence how we interpret current circumstances.

Sometimes we respond to the present situation. Other times, we are responding to something the situation reminds us of.

Writing prompts:

1. What situations consistently trigger strong emotional reactions in me?
2. What memories or experiences might be connected to those reactions?
3. Have I ever treated someone as though they were responsible for something another person did?
4. What emotional patterns do I seem to repeat?
5. How can I recognize when my past is influencing my present?

Deeper question:

Am I responding to what is happening now, or am I trying to prevent something that happened before from happening again?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 5: What Am I Projecting?

Theme: Recognizing myself in others

Sometimes the things that bother us most about other people reveal something about our own unresolved feelings, insecurities, or expectations.

Today is about honest self-examination, not self-blame.

Writing prompts:

1. What characteristics in other people provoke the strongest reactions in me?
2. Do I recognize any of those characteristics in myself?
3. What assumptions do I make about other people's intentions?
4. Do I sometimes attribute feelings to others that I have difficulty acknowledging in myself?
5. What might I discover if I became more curious and less judgmental?

Deeper question:

What am I unwilling to recognize about myself that I may be criticizing in someone else?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 6: The Need to Be Right

Theme: Releasing attachment to certainty

Being right can become more important than discovering the truth.

We defend our positions, gather information that supports our beliefs, and sometimes resist evidence that challenges them.

Writing prompts:

1. How do I react when someone challenges something I strongly believe?
2. Do I become curious or defensive?
3. Have I ever changed my mind about something important?
4. What makes admitting that I was wrong difficult?
5. Where in my life might I be protecting a belief instead of examining it?

Deeper question:

Would I rather discover the truth or preserve my certainty?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 7: Compassion Without Self-Abandonment

Theme: Understanding boundaries

Compassion is valuable, but it does not require us to sacrifice our emotional well-being.

We can understand someone's pain without accepting responsibility for fixing it.

Writing prompts:

1. Where in my life do I take responsibility for other people's emotions?
2. Do I feel guilty when I say no?
3. Have I ever confused being needed with being loved?
4. Do I make excuses for behavior because I understand someone's history?
5. What boundary would improve my emotional well-being right now?

Deeper question:

Where have I mistaken self-sacrifice for compassion?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 8: When Spirituality Becomes Avoidance

Theme: Recognizing spiritual bypassing

Spiritual beliefs can help us navigate difficult experiences, but they can also become a way to avoid emotional discomfort.

Today, examine where your spiritual beliefs support your growth and where they might protect you from necessary work.

Writing prompts:

1. Have I ever used the phrase "everything happens for a reason" to avoid acknowledging pain?
2. Do I allow myself to experience anger, grief, disappointment, and frustration?
3. Have I confused forgiveness with reconciliation?
4. Have I ever stayed in an unhealthy situation because I believed I was supposed to be compassionate?
5. What emotional work have I been avoiding?

Deeper question:

Am I using spirituality to help me face reality or to help me avoid it?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 9: The Stories I Tell Myself

Theme: Separating interpretation from reality

We all create stories about ourselves, other people, and the world.

Some stories help us understand our experiences. Others keep us trapped in outdated beliefs.

Writing prompts:

1. What story do I repeatedly tell myself about who I am?
2. What story do I tell about why certain things happen to me?
3. Are these stories based on current evidence or old experiences?
4. What would happen if I considered a completely different explanation?
5. Which personal narrative might I be ready to release?

Deeper question:

What if the story I have been telling myself is no longer true?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 10: Can I Sit With Not Knowing?

Theme: Developing tolerance for uncertainty

Many of our most exhausting emotional experiences come from trying to obtain certainty where certainty is unavailable.

We want to know what someone thinks, what will happen next, whether we made the right decision, and whether everything will work out.

Sometimes we simply cannot know.

Writing prompts:

1. What unanswered question in my life causes me the most discomfort?
2. Why do I feel I need an answer?
3. What do I imagine will happen if I never receive that answer?
4. How do I behave when I feel uncertain?
5. Can I make a meaningful decision without knowing every possible outcome?

Deeper question:

What would it mean to trust myself even when I cannot predict the future?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 11: The Difference Between Potential and Reality

Theme: Seeing people and situations as they are

We sometimes become attached to what something could be rather than what it actually is.

This happens in relationships, careers, friendships, and even our spiritual expectations.

Writing prompts:

1. Is there a person or situation in my life that I am holding onto because of its potential?
2. What does the actual evidence tell me?
3. Am I waiting for someone to become the person I believe they could be?
4. What promises have I accepted in place of consistent behavior?
5. What would I choose if I evaluated this situation exactly as it exists today?

Deeper question:

Am I attached to reality or to the possibility of what I wish reality would become?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 12: My Relationship With External Validation

Theme: Reclaiming inner authority

Advice, readings, opinions, and outside perspectives can be valuable.

But when we constantly seek reassurance, we may gradually stop trusting our own ability to make decisions.

Writing prompts:

1. Whose approval do I seek most often?
2. Do I ask for advice when I really want someone to tell me what to do?
3. Have I ever ignored my own judgment because someone else disagreed?
4. Do I repeatedly seek reassurance after making a decision?
5. What would trusting myself look like in a practical situation this week?

Deeper question:

Am I seeking guidance or permission?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 13: The Integrity of My Intuition

Theme: Taking responsibility for interpretation

Being intuitive does not mean every impression is accurate.

Developing discernment means being willing to evaluate our perceptions, recognize our limitations, and acknowledge when we have misinterpreted something.

Writing prompts:

1. Have I ever been wrong about an intuitive impression?
2. How did I respond when I discovered I was wrong?
3. Do I sometimes interpret ambiguous experiences in ways that confirm what I already believe?
4. Do I feel pressure to be right when offering spiritual guidance to others?
5. How can I maintain spiritual openness while practicing intellectual honesty?

Deeper question:

Can I remain confident in my intuitive abilities without needing to believe every impression is correct?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 14: What Does Discernment Look Like in My Everyday Life?

Theme: Putting awareness into practice

Discernment is not something we practice only during spiritual experiences or difficult emotional situations.

It is an everyday skill.

It influences our conversations, relationships, decisions, boundaries, and responses to the world around us.

Writing prompts:

1. What have I noticed about my thinking patterns over the past two weeks?
2. Which fear-based patterns have become more recognizable?
3. Where have I become more aware of my assumptions?
4. What boundaries have I recognized that I need to establish?
5. What is one situation in my life where I can consciously practice discernment today?

Deeper question:

What would change if I approached every important decision with curiosity instead of immediate certainty?

YOUR NOTES

DAY 15: Becoming the Authority of My Own Life

Theme: Integration and personal accountability

Discernment ultimately requires us to take responsibility for how we interpret and respond to our experiences.

It does not mean we will always be right.

It means we are willing to question ourselves, gather information, examine our emotional responses, and make thoughtful decisions.

Today is about recognizing the person you are becoming.

Writing prompts:

1. What has this process taught me about myself?
2. What belief have I questioned most deeply?
3. What have I discovered about the relationship between fear and intuition?
4. Where do I need to become more accountable for my interpretations?
5. What does inner authority mean to me?
6. What am I no longer willing to confuse with truth?
7. What three practices will I continue after completing this journal?

Final reflection:

Complete these statements:

- I used to believe...
- I now recognize...
- I have been afraid to admit...
- I am ready to question...
- I am learning to trust...
- I am no longer willing to...
- My understanding of discernment is...

My Personal Discernment Commitment

I recognize that my feelings are real, but my interpretations may require examination.

I recognize that intuition is valuable, but it does not make me infallible.

I recognize that spirituality and psychology can work together.

I give myself permission to question, reconsider, change my mind, establish boundaries, and acknowledge uncertainty.

I do not need to have all the answers to trust myself.

I commit to remaining curious, honest, compassionate, and accountable.

Signed: _____

Date: _____

AFTER THE FIFTEEN DAYS

Return to this journal whenever you encounter a situation that challenges your ability to distinguish fear, intuition, emotion, and belief.

Discernment is not a test you pass.

It is a relationship you develop with yourself.

The more willing you are to examine your own thinking, the less likely you are to be controlled by unexamined assumptions, emotional reactions, or the need for certainty.

The goal is not to question everything you know. It is to know why you believe what you believe.